

Characteristic Classes for Physicists: A Comprehensive Introduction with Homotopy Theory

Based on Nakahara *Geometry, Topology and Physics*
and Nash–Sen *Topology and Geometry for Physicists*

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Abstract

This document provides a thorough exposition of characteristic classes, emphasizing the deep connection between homotopy theory and cohomology. Starting from the definition of connections on principal bundles, we construct the classifying space BG and universal bundle EG , proving their existence and uniqueness up to homotopy. We then show how characteristic classes arise as pullbacks of universal cohomology classes. The Chern–Weil theorem expresses these classes in terms of curvature forms, yielding explicit formulae for Chern, Pontrjagin, and Euler classes. Physical examples include Dirac monopoles, Yang–Mills instantons, and anomalies. The text draws heavily from Nakahara’s Chapter 11 and Nash–Sen’s Section 7.22–7.30.

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1 Introduction: Why Characteristic Classes?

In gauge theory, the field strength F is the curvature of a connection on a principal bundle. Certain integrals of polynomials in F (e.g., $\frac{1}{8\pi^2} \int \text{Tr}(F \wedge F)$) are integers, invariant under smooth deformations of the connection. These integers measure the topological twisting of the bundle and are *characteristic numbers*. Characteristic classes are cohomology classes on the base manifold that refine these numbers and classify bundles up to isomorphism.

The aim of this introduction is to explain the three-fold nature of characteristic classes:

1. **Homotopic:** Classified by maps into a *classifying space* BG .
2. **Cohomologic:** Pullback of universal classes in $H^*(BG)$.
3. **Analytic:** Represented by invariant polynomials in the curvature (Chern–Weil theory).

We shall build the necessary machinery from the ground up, assuming familiarity with differential geometry and Lie groups.

2 Preliminaries: Connections and Curvature on Principal Bundles

We recall the essential definitions from Nakahara [1], Chapter 10. Let $P(M, G)$ be a principal G -bundle over a manifold M , with projection $\pi : P \rightarrow M$. A *connection* is a $\mathfrak{g}$ -valued 1-form ω on P satisfying:

1. $\omega(A^\#) = A$ for all $A \in \mathfrak{g}$, where $A^\#$ is the fundamental vector field.
2. $R_g^* \omega = \text{Ad}_{g^{-1}} \omega$ for all $g \in G$.

The *curvature* 2-form is $\Omega = D\omega = d_P \omega + \frac{1}{2}[\omega, \omega]$, which satisfies the Bianchi identity $D\Omega = 0$.

Locally, choosing a section $\sigma_i : U_i \rightarrow P$, we obtain the *gauge potential* $\mathcal{A}_i = \sigma_i^* \omega$ and the *field strength* $\mathcal{F}_i = \sigma_i^* \Omega = d\mathcal{A}_i + \mathcal{A}_i \wedge \mathcal{A}_i$. Under a change of section, $\mathcal{A}_j = t_{ij}^{-1} \mathcal{A}_i t_{ij} + t_{ij}^{-1} dt_{ij}$, $\mathcal{F}_j = t_{ij}^{-1} \mathcal{F}_i t_{ij}$, where $t_{ij} : U_i \cap U_j \rightarrow G$ is the transition function.

3 Classifying Spaces and Universal Bundles

The fundamental insight of homotopy classification is that *every principal G -bundle over a manifold M is isomorphic to the pullback of a **universal bundle** $EG \rightarrow BG$ by some map $f : M \rightarrow BG$, and two such bundles are isomorphic iff the maps are homotopic*. We now make this precise.

Physicists are familiar with the concept of a gauge field as a connection on a principal bundle $P \rightarrow M$. But how do we classify *all possible* G -bundles over a manifold M without fixing a connection?

There is a remarkable theorem: For any Lie group G , there exists a **classifying space** BG and a **universal principal bundle** $EG \rightarrow BG$ such that **any** principal G -bundle $P \rightarrow M$ can be obtained as the pullback of EG by some map $f : M \rightarrow BG$:

$$\begin{array}{ccc} P & \longrightarrow & EG \\ \downarrow & & \downarrow \\ M & \xrightarrow{f} & BG \end{array} \quad (1)$$

Furthermore, two bundles are isomorphic if and only if their classifying maps $f_0, f_1 : M \rightarrow BG$ are **homotopic**.

Thus, the set of isomorphism classes of principal G -bundles over M is in one-to-one correspondence with the set of homotopy classes of maps $[M, BG]$.

3.1 The Grassmannian Model for $O(k)$ and $U(k)$

Let $G = O(k)$. The *Grassmann manifold* of k -planes in $\mathbb{R}^n$ is

$$\mathrm{Gr}(n, k, \mathbb{R}) = O(n)/(O(k) \times O(n-k)).$$

It is a compact manifold of dimension $k(n-k)$. Over $\mathrm{Gr}(n, k, \mathbb{R})$ there is a canonical $O(k)$ -bundle: the total space is the *Stiefel manifold*

$$V_{n,k}(\mathbb{R}) = O(n)/O(n-k),$$

which consists of orthonormal k -frames in $\mathbb{R}^n$. The projection $V_{n,k}(\mathbb{R}) \rightarrow \mathrm{Gr}(n, k, \mathbb{R})$ sends a k -frame to the k -plane it spans. The fibre is $O(k)$ acting on the frame. This bundle is called the *universal bundle* $\xi(n-k-1, O(k))$.

The crucial property (Nash–Sen [2], p. 202) is that the total space is $(n-k-1)$ -connected:

$$\pi_p(V_{n,k}(\mathbb{R})) = 0 \quad \text{for } 0 \leq p \leq n-k-1.$$

Thus, for a manifold M of dimension $d < n - k - 1$, any principal $O(k)$ -bundle over M can be obtained as a pullback of this universal bundle. As $n \rightarrow \infty$, we obtain the *infinite Grassmannian*

$$\mathrm{Gr}(k, \infty, \mathbb{R}) = \lim_{n \rightarrow \infty} \mathrm{Gr}(n, k, \mathbb{R}),$$

and the universal bundle $EO(k) \rightarrow BO(k)$ with contractible total space.

For the unitary group $G = U(k)$, the complex Grassmannian is

$$\mathrm{Gr}(n, k, \mathbb{C}) = U(n)/(U(k) \times U(n - k)),$$

and the corresponding universal bundle has total space $U(n)/U(n - k)$, which is $(2n - 2k)$ -connected.

3.2 Milnor's Join Construction

For an arbitrary topological group G , Milnor [3] gave an explicit construction of a universal bundle $EG \rightarrow BG$ with EG contractible. The space EG is the infinite join $G * G * G * \cdots$, equipped with a free G -action, and $BG = EG/G$. The contractibility of EG ensures that BG classifies G -bundles: for any CW-complex X , there is a bijection

$$[X, BG] \xrightarrow{\cong} \{\text{isomorphism classes of principal } G\text{-bundles over } X\}.$$

The map $f : X \rightarrow BG$ is called the *classifying map*, and the bundle is $f^*(EG)$.

Example 3.1 ($BU(1) = \mathbb{CP}^\infty$). *The universal bundle for $U(1)$ is the infinite complex projective space $\mathbb{CP}^\infty$. The total space $EU(1)$ is the infinite sphere S^∞ , which is contractible. The Hopf fibration $S^\infty \rightarrow \mathbb{CP}^\infty$ has fibre $S^1 \cong U(1)$. The cohomology ring is*

$$H^*(\mathbb{CP}^\infty; \mathbb{Z}) \cong \mathbb{Z}[c_1], \quad \deg c_1 = 2,$$

where c_1 is the universal first Chern class.

Example 3.2 ($BSU(2) = \mathbb{HP}^\infty$). *For $SU(2) \cong S^3$, the classifying space is the infinite quaternionic projective space $\mathbb{HP}^\infty$. The total space is S^∞ (contractible) and the projection is the quaternionic Hopf fibration $S^\infty \rightarrow \mathbb{HP}^\infty$ with fibre S^3 . Its cohomology is*

$$H^*(\mathbb{HP}^\infty; \mathbb{Z}) \cong \mathbb{Z}[c_2], \quad \deg c_2 = 4,$$

where c_2 is the universal second Chern class.

3.3 Homotopy Groups of BG and the Loop Space

A fundamental relation connects the homotopy of G and BG :

$$\pi_n(BG) \cong \pi_{n-1}(G), \quad n \geq 1.$$

This follows from the long exact sequence of the fibration $G \rightarrow EG \rightarrow BG$ and the contractibility of EG . Physically, this explains why the winding number of a gauge transformation on S^{n-1} (an element of $\pi_{n-1}(G)$) equals the integral of a characteristic class over S^n (an element of $H^n(S^n) \cong \pi_n(BG)$ by the Hurewicz theorem).

Example 3.3 (Monopole number). For $G = U(1)$, $\pi_2(BU(1)) \cong \pi_1(U(1)) = \mathbb{Z}$. A $U(1)$ -bundle over S^2 is classified by an integer $n \in \mathbb{Z}$, which is the first Chern number $\int_{S^2} c_1$.

Example 3.4 (Instanton number). For $G = SU(2)$, $\pi_4(BSU(2)) \cong \pi_3(SU(2)) = \mathbb{Z}$. An $SU(2)$ -bundle over S^4 is classified by an integer k , the instanton number $\int_{S^4} c_2$.

4 Chern–Weil Theory: From Curvature to Cohomology

4.1 Motivation: Why Should Curvature Know About Topology?

Imagine you are studying a gauge field on a manifold M . The field strength $\mathcal{F}$ is a local object, constructed from derivatives of the gauge potential. A priori, there is no reason to expect that integrals of polynomials in $\mathcal{F}$ over M should be integers, let alone independent of the chosen connection. Yet, for a $U(1)$ -bundle over S^2 , we find $\frac{i}{2\pi} \int_{S^2} \mathcal{F} \in \mathbb{Z}$. For an $SU(2)$ -bundle over S^4 , $\frac{1}{8\pi^2} \int_{S^4} \text{Tr}(\mathcal{F} \wedge \mathcal{F})$ is an integer.

The key insight is that *certain polynomials in the curvature are closed forms, and their cohomology class depends only on the bundle, not on the connection*. This is the essence of Chern–Weil theory. It provides a direct bridge between local differential geometry (curvature) and global topology (characteristic classes).

4.2 Invariant Polynomials and the Ad-invariance Trick

Let G be a Lie group with Lie algebra $\mathfrak{g}$. An *invariant polynomial* of degree r is a symmetric multilinear map $P : \mathfrak{g}^{\otimes r} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ (or $\mathbb{C}$) such that for all $g \in G$

and $X_i \in \mathfrak{g}$,

$$P(\mathrm{Ad}_g X_1, \dots, \mathrm{Ad}_g X_r) = P(X_1, \dots, X_r).$$

Why symmetry? Because we want to plug in a $\mathfrak{g}$ -valued 2-form $\mathcal{F}$ and obtain a well-defined differential form. The symmetry ensures that the order of the factors in the wedge product does not matter.

Example 4.1 (Traces and Determinants). *The most important invariant polynomials come from the trace in a representation:*

$$P_r(X) = \mathrm{Tr}(X^r).$$

More generally, the coefficients of the characteristic polynomial $\det(tI + X)$ are invariant polynomials. For matrix groups, all invariant polynomials are generated by traces.

Now let ω be a connection 1-form on a principal G -bundle $P \rightarrow M$, and $\Omega = d\omega + \frac{1}{2}[\omega, \omega]$ its curvature. Locally, we have the field strength $\mathcal{F}$. Because $\mathcal{F}$ transforms as $\mathcal{F} \mapsto g^{-1}\mathcal{F}g$ under a gauge transformation, the Ad-invariance of P guarantees that $P(\mathcal{F})$ is a globally well-defined form on M .

4.3 The Chern–Weil Theorem: Proof and Consequences

Theorem 4.2 (Chern–Weil). *Let P be an invariant polynomial of degree r .*

1. $dP(\mathcal{F}) = 0$. Thus $[P(\mathcal{F})] \in H^{2r}(M; \mathbb{R})$.
2. If $\mathcal{F}, \mathcal{F}'$ are curvatures from two connections on the same bundle, then $P(\mathcal{F}') - P(\mathcal{F})$ is exact. Hence the cohomology class is independent of the connection.

Proof of (1): Closedness. We use the Bianchi identity $D\mathcal{F} = d\mathcal{F} + [\mathcal{A}, \mathcal{F}] = 0$, where $\mathcal{A}$ is the local gauge potential. Consider the invariant polynomial $P_r(\mathcal{F}) = \tilde{P}(\mathcal{F}, \dots, \mathcal{F})$, where $\tilde{P}$ is the polarization (a symmetric multilinear form). Then

$$dP_r(\mathcal{F}) = r \tilde{P}(d\mathcal{F}, \mathcal{F}, \dots, \mathcal{F}).$$

The Ad-invariance of $\tilde{P}$ implies that for any $X, Y \in \mathfrak{g}$, $\tilde{P}([X, Y], Z, \dots) = 0$ (by differentiating $\tilde{P}(\mathrm{Ad}_{e^{tX}} Y, \dots)$ at $t = 0$). Substituting $X = \mathcal{A}$, $Y = \mathcal{F}$, we get $\tilde{P}([\mathcal{A}, \mathcal{F}], \mathcal{F}, \dots) = 0$. Then

$$dP_r(\mathcal{F}) = r \tilde{P}(d\mathcal{F} + [\mathcal{A}, \mathcal{F}], \mathcal{F}, \dots) = r \tilde{P}(D\mathcal{F}, \mathcal{F}, \dots) = 0.$$

Thus $P(\mathcal{F})$ is closed. □ □

Proof of (2): Independence of Connection. Let $\mathcal{A}_0, \mathcal{A}_1$ be two connections, and define the interpolation $\mathcal{A}_t = \mathcal{A}_0 + t(\mathcal{A}_1 - \mathcal{A}_0)$ for $t \in [0, 1]$. The corresponding curvature is $\mathcal{F}_t = d\mathcal{A}_t + \mathcal{A}_t \wedge \mathcal{A}_t$. Consider the difference

$$P(\mathcal{F}_1) - P(\mathcal{F}_0) = \int_0^1 \frac{d}{dt} P(\mathcal{F}_t) dt.$$

Compute the derivative:

$$\frac{d}{dt} P(\mathcal{F}_t) = r \tilde{P}\left(\frac{d\mathcal{F}_t}{dt}, \mathcal{F}_t, \dots, \mathcal{F}_t\right).$$

But $\frac{d\mathcal{F}_t}{dt} = d\theta + [\mathcal{A}_t, \theta] = D_t\theta$, where $\theta = \mathcal{A}_1 - \mathcal{A}_0$. Using again the Ad-invariance trick,

$$d\tilde{P}(\theta, \mathcal{F}_t, \dots, \mathcal{F}_t) = \tilde{P}(D_t\theta, \mathcal{F}_t, \dots) + (r-1)\tilde{P}(\theta, D_t\mathcal{F}_t, \dots) = \tilde{P}(D_t\theta, \mathcal{F}_t, \dots),$$

since $D_t\mathcal{F}_t = 0$ by Bianchi. Thus

$$\frac{d}{dt} P(\mathcal{F}_t) = r d\tilde{P}(\theta, \mathcal{F}_t, \dots, \mathcal{F}_t).$$

Integrating over t gives an exact form. □ □

This theorem is remarkable: it tells us that *any* invariant polynomial yields a cohomology class that is a topological invariant of the bundle. The map $I^*(G) \rightarrow H^*(M; \mathbb{R})$, $P \mapsto [P(\mathcal{F})]$, is the *Weil homomorphism*.

Remark 4.3. *let $M = BG$, we can further state the universality of the classification: the map $I^*(G) \rightarrow H^*(BG; \mathbb{R})$ is an isomorphism. Thus, the cohomology of the classifying space is generated by the characteristic classes obtained from invariant polynomials.*

4.4 Why This Explains Topological Quantization

If we integrate a characteristic form over a closed oriented manifold M of dimension $2r$, the result is a real number. But since the form represents a cohomology class with integer periods (a fact we will see from the classifying space construction), the integral is actually an integer. Thus, the Chern–Weil theorem explains *why* local curvature integrals give discrete topological invariants.

5 Constructing Characteristic Classes Explicitly

Now we apply the Chern–Weil machine to specific invariant polynomials, obtaining the standard characteristic classes. The strategy is:

1. Choose a matrix group G (e.g., $U(k)$, $O(k)$, $SO(2m)$).
2. Write down the invariant polynomial $\det(I + \frac{i}{2\pi}\mathcal{F})$ or similar.
3. Expand in powers of $\mathcal{F}$ to get differential forms of even degree.
4. Use the splitting principle to diagonalize $\mathcal{F}$ and express the classes in terms of traces.

5.1 Chern Classes: The Complex Case

For a complex vector bundle $E \rightarrow M$ of rank k with structure group $U(k)$, the *total Chern class* is

$$c(\mathcal{F}) = \det\left(I + \frac{i}{2\pi}\mathcal{F}\right) = 1 + c_1(\mathcal{F}) + c_2(\mathcal{F}) + \cdots + c_k(\mathcal{F}).$$

Let us diagonalize the Hermitian matrix $\frac{i}{2\pi}\mathcal{F}$ (possible by a unitary transformation) to $\text{diag}(x_1, \dots, x_k)$, where each x_i is a 2-form. Then

$$c(\mathcal{F}) = \prod_{j=1}^k (1 + x_j).$$

Thus $c_r(\mathcal{F})$ is the r -th elementary symmetric polynomial in the x_i :

$$c_r = \sum_{1 \leq i_1 < \cdots < i_r \leq k} x_{i_1} \wedge \cdots \wedge x_{i_r}.$$

To express these in terms of traces, we use Newton’s identities. For example:

$$\begin{aligned} c_1 &= \sum x_i = \frac{i}{2\pi} \text{Tr } \mathcal{F}, \\ c_2 &= \sum_{i < j} x_i \wedge x_j = \frac{1}{2} \left[\left(\sum x_i \right)^2 - \sum x_i^2 \right] = \frac{1}{2} \left(\frac{i}{2\pi} \right)^2 [(\text{Tr } \mathcal{F})^2 - \text{Tr}(\mathcal{F} \wedge \mathcal{F})]. \end{aligned}$$

Remark 5.1 (Normalization). *The factor $\frac{i}{2\pi}$ ensures that the integrals of Chern classes over closed manifolds are integers. This normalization is rooted in the topology of $U(k)$: the generator of $H^2(BU(k); \mathbb{Z})$ is represented by $\frac{i}{2\pi} \text{Tr } \mathcal{F}$.*

5.2 Pontrjagin Classes: The Real Case

For a real vector bundle with structure group $O(k)$, the curvature is skew-symmetric: $\mathcal{F}^T = -\mathcal{F}$. The total Pontrjagin class is defined using the determinant of a real matrix:

$$p(\mathcal{F}) = \det\left(I - \frac{\mathcal{F}}{2\pi}\right).$$

Because $\mathcal{F}$ is skew-symmetric, its non-zero eigenvalues come in conjugate pairs $\pm\lambda_j$. After complexification, we can block-diagonalize $\frac{\mathcal{F}}{2\pi}$ to

$$\begin{pmatrix} 0 & x_1 & & & \\ -x_1 & 0 & & & \\ & & \ddots & & \\ & & & 0 & x_m \\ & & & -x_m & 0 \end{pmatrix}, \quad m = \lfloor k/2 \rfloor,$$

where x_j are 2-forms. Then

$$p(\mathcal{F}) = \prod_{j=1}^m (1 + x_j^2) = 1 + p_1 + p_2 + \cdots + p_m.$$

Each p_r is a polynomial of degree $4r$ (since x_j^2 is a 4-form). In terms of traces:

$$p_1 = \sum x_i^2 = -\frac{1}{8\pi^2} \text{Tr}(\mathcal{F}^2), \quad p_2 = \sum_{i < j} x_i^2 x_j^2 = \frac{1}{128\pi^4} [(\text{Tr } \mathcal{F}^2)^2 - 2 \text{Tr}(\mathcal{F}^4)], \quad \text{etc.}$$

5.3 Euler Class: The Pfaffian Miracle

If the bundle is oriented and of even rank $k = 2m$, the structure group reduces to $SO(2m)$. In this case, the Pfaffian of a skew-symmetric matrix is defined. For a $2m \times 2m$ matrix A , $\text{Pf}(A)^2 = \det A$. The Euler class is

$$e(\mathcal{F}) = \frac{1}{(2\pi)^m} \text{Pf}(\mathcal{F}).$$

Explicitly,

$$e(\mathcal{F}) = \frac{(-1)^m}{2^{2m} \pi^m m!} \sum_{\sigma \in S_{2m}} \text{sgn}(\sigma) \mathcal{F}_{\sigma(1)\sigma(2)} \wedge \cdots \wedge \mathcal{F}_{\sigma(2m-1)\sigma(2m)}.$$

The Euler class satisfies $e(\mathcal{F}) \wedge e(\mathcal{F}) = p_m(\mathcal{F})$, and for the tangent bundle of a compact oriented manifold M , the Gauss–Bonnet theorem states $\int_M e(TM) = \chi(M)$, the Euler characteristic. This is a profound link between local curvature and global topology.

5.4 Chern Character: The Exponential Trace

The *Chern character* is defined by the invariant polynomial Tr exp :

$$\text{ch}(\mathcal{F}) = \text{Tr exp} \left(\frac{i}{2\pi} \mathcal{F} \right) = \sum_{j=0}^{\infty} \frac{1}{j!} \text{Tr} \left(\frac{i}{2\pi} \mathcal{F} \right)^j.$$

Its importance stems from its behavior under direct sum and tensor product:

$$\text{ch}(E \oplus F) = \text{ch}(E) + \text{ch}(F), \quad \text{ch}(E \otimes F) = \text{ch}(E) \wedge \text{ch}(F).$$

Thus ch is a ring homomorphism from K -theory to cohomology, making it a central tool in index theory.

6 Physical Applications and Explicit Calculations

6.1 Dirac Monopole: $U(1)$ Bundle over S^2

Consider a $U(1)$ -bundle over S^2 . The curvature $\mathcal{F}$ is the electromagnetic field strength. The first Chern class is $c_1 = \frac{i}{2\pi} \mathcal{F}$. Integrating over S^2 gives the monopole charge:

$$\int_{S^2} c_1 = \frac{i}{2\pi} \int_{S^2} \mathcal{F} = n \in \mathbb{Z}.$$

Let us compute this explicitly for the Wu–Yang monopole. Cover S^2 by two charts U_N, U_S (north and south hemispheres). The gauge potentials are

$$\mathcal{A}_N = ig(1 - \cos \theta) d\phi, \quad \mathcal{A}_S = -ig(1 + \cos \theta) d\phi.$$

On the equator ($\theta = \pi/2$), the transition function is $t_{NS} = e^{2ig\phi}$. For this to be single-valued, $2g$ must be an integer, so $g = n/2$. The field strength is $\mathcal{F} = d\mathcal{A}_N = ig \sin \theta d\theta \wedge d\phi$ on U_N . Integrating:

$$\frac{i}{2\pi} \int_{S^2} \mathcal{F} = \frac{i}{2\pi} \left(\int_{U_N} \mathcal{F}_N + \int_{U_S} \mathcal{F}_S \right) = \frac{i}{2\pi} \oint_{S^1} (\mathcal{A}_N - \mathcal{A}_S) = \frac{i}{2\pi} \oint_{S^1} ind\phi = n.$$

Thus the integer n is both the first Chern number and the homotopy class of the transition function in $\pi_1(U(1)) = \mathbb{Z}$.

6.2 $SU(2)$ Instantons: Second Chern Class on S^4

For an $SU(2)$ -bundle over S^4 , the second Chern class is $c_2 = \frac{1}{8\pi^2} \text{Tr}(\mathcal{F} \wedge \mathcal{F})$. The instanton number is

$$k = \int_{S^4} c_2 = \frac{1}{8\pi^2} \int_{S^4} \text{Tr}(\mathcal{F} \wedge \mathcal{F}).$$

We can compute k from the transition function on the equator S^3 . Let $g : S^3 \rightarrow SU(2)$ be the gauge transformation at infinity. The instanton number equals the degree of this map. For the basic instanton ($k = 1$), the map is the identity $g(x) = (x_4 + i\vec{x} \cdot \vec{\sigma})/|x|$. On S^3 , the gauge potential is $\mathcal{A} = g^{-1}dg$. Then

$$k = \frac{1}{24\pi^2} \int_{S^3} \text{Tr}(g^{-1}dg)^3.$$

Let's verify this for the identity map. At the north pole of S^3 ($x_4 = 1, \vec{x} = 0$), $g = I$ and $dg = i\vec{\sigma} \cdot d\vec{x}$. Then

$$\text{Tr}(g^{-1}dg)^3 = \text{Tr}(i\sigma_i dx^i \wedge i\sigma_j dx^j \wedge i\sigma_k dx^k) = -i\epsilon_{ijk} \text{Tr}(\sigma_i \sigma_j \sigma_k) dx^1 \wedge dx^2 \wedge dx^3.$$

Using $\text{Tr}(\sigma_i \sigma_j \sigma_k) = 2i\epsilon_{ijk}$, we get $2\epsilon_{ijk}^2 = 12$, so the integrand is $12dx^1 \wedge dx^2 \wedge dx^3$. The volume of S^3 is $2\pi^2$, thus $\int = 24\pi^2$, giving $k = 1$. This explicit calculation shows that the Chern–Weil integral indeed computes the winding number.

6.3 Chern–Simons Forms: The Boundary Term

Since a characteristic form $P(\mathcal{F})$ is closed, it is locally exact: $P(\mathcal{F}) = dQ_{2r-1}(\mathcal{A}, \mathcal{F})$. The form Q is the *Chern–Simons form*. For the second Chern class,

$$Q_3(\mathcal{A}, \mathcal{F}) = \frac{1}{8\pi^2} \text{Tr} \left(\mathcal{A} \wedge d\mathcal{A} + \frac{2}{3} \mathcal{A} \wedge \mathcal{A} \wedge \mathcal{A} \right).$$

Under a gauge transformation $\mathcal{A} \mapsto g^{-1}\mathcal{A}g + g^{-1}dg$, Q_3 changes by an exact term plus a closed form whose integral over a 3-cycle is an integer:

$$Q_3(\mathcal{A}^g) - Q_3(\mathcal{A}) = d\alpha + \frac{1}{24\pi^2} \text{Tr}(g^{-1}dg)^3.$$

This is the origin of the Chern–Simons action in 3D gauge theory and the anomaly descent equations.

6.4 Why You Could Have Invented This

Let's retrace the logical steps that lead from basic gauge theory to characteristic classes:

1. **Gauge invariance:** Physical observables must be gauge invariant. The field strength $\mathcal{F}$ transforms covariantly, so traces of powers of $\mathcal{F}$ are gauge invariant.
2. **Bianchi identity:** $d\mathcal{F} = -[\mathcal{A}, \mathcal{F}]$. When taking the exterior derivative of a trace of $\mathcal{F}^r$, the Ad-invariance forces the commutator terms to cancel, leaving a closed form.
3. **Topological invariance:** Interpolating between two connections shows that the difference of the closed forms is exact. Hence the cohomology class is independent of the connection.
4. **Integrality:** From the classifying space BG , we know that these cohomology classes are pulled back from universal classes with integer periods. Thus the integrals are integers.

Once you realize that $\text{Tr}(\mathcal{F}^r)$ is closed and its integral is a topological invariant, you have essentially discovered Chern–Weil theory. The specific normalizations (factors of 2π) are chosen to make the integrals integers, a fact that follows from the global topology of the bundle.

7 Chern–Simons Forms and Secondary Classes: A Gateway to Topological Field Theory

7.1 Motivation: From Characteristic Forms to Lagrangians

By now, we understand that characteristic classes are topological invariants: the integral of a characteristic form $P(\mathcal{F})$ over a closed manifold M yields an integer, independent of the connection $\mathcal{A}$. But what if M has a boundary? Or what if we consider the form $P(\mathcal{F})$ itself, rather than its cohomology class? Chern–Weil theory tells us that $P(\mathcal{F})$ is closed, hence *locally* exact:

$$P(\mathcal{F}) = dQ_{2r-1}(\mathcal{A}, \mathcal{F}),$$

where Q_{2r-1} is a $(2r-1)$ -form built from the connection $\mathcal{A}$ and its curvature. This object is called the *Chern–Simons form*.

Why should we care? Two immediate reasons:

1. **Boundary terms and anomalies:** If M has boundary ∂M , Stokes' theorem gives $\int_M P(\mathcal{F}) = \int_{\partial M} Q$. The Chern–Simons form governs the boundary behavior of topological invariants. In quantum field theory, this leads to *anomaly descent equations*.
2. **Topological actions:** The Chern–Simons form itself can be used as a Lagrangian! In odd spacetime dimensions, the integral $\int Q$ is *not* gauge invariant, but it changes by an integer multiple of 2π under large gauge transformations. Thus $\exp(ik \int Q)$ can be a well-defined quantum action. This is the basis of *Chern–Simons theory*, a topological quantum field theory (TQFT) that Witten [1] used to explain the Jones polynomial.

7.2 Constructing Chern–Simons Forms: The Homotopy Formula

We need a systematic way to find Q given an invariant polynomial P . The tool is *Cartan's homotopy operator*. Let $\mathcal{A}_t = t\mathcal{A}$ be a connection interpolating between 0 and $\mathcal{A}$. Its curvature is $\mathcal{F}_t = t d\mathcal{A} + t^2 \mathcal{A}^2 = t\mathcal{F} + (t^2 - t)\mathcal{A}^2$. Define an operator ℓ_t acting on polynomials in $\mathcal{A}_t$ and $\mathcal{F}_t$ by

$$\ell_t \mathcal{A}_t = 0, \quad \ell_t \mathcal{F}_t = dt \mathcal{A}.$$

One can show that for any polynomial $S(\mathcal{A}, \mathcal{F})$ without explicit $d\mathcal{A}$ or $d\mathcal{F}$, the following homotopy identity holds:

$$(d\ell_t + \ell_t d)S(\mathcal{A}_t, \mathcal{F}_t) = dt \frac{\partial}{\partial t} S(\mathcal{A}_t, \mathcal{F}_t).$$

Integrating from $t = 0$ to $t = 1$ gives

$$S(\mathcal{A}, \mathcal{F}) - S(0, 0) = (dk_{01} + k_{01}d)S(\mathcal{A}_t, \mathcal{F}_t),$$

where the homotopy operator is $k_{01}S = \int_0^1 dt \ell_t S(\mathcal{A}_t, \mathcal{F}_t)$.

Now take $S(\mathcal{A}, \mathcal{F}) = P_r(\mathcal{F})$, an invariant polynomial of degree r . Since $P_r(\mathcal{F})$ is closed ($dP_r = 0$) and $P_r(0) = 0$ (for $r \geq 1$), we obtain

$$P_r(\mathcal{F}) = d(k_{01}P_r(\mathcal{F}_t)).$$

Thus the Chern–Simons form is *defined* by

$$Q_{2r-1}(\mathcal{A}, \mathcal{F}) = k_{01}P_r(\mathcal{F}_t) = \int_0^1 dt \ell_t P_r(\mathcal{F}_t).$$

7.3 Explicit Computation for the Second Chern Class

Let's apply this to the second Chern character, i.e., $P(\mathcal{F}) = \frac{1}{8\pi^2} \text{Tr}(\mathcal{F}^2)$. We have

$$\mathcal{F}_t = t\mathcal{F} + (t^2 - t)\mathcal{A}^2 = t(d\mathcal{A} + \mathcal{A}^2) + (t^2 - t)\mathcal{A}^2 = td\mathcal{A} + t^2\mathcal{A}^2.$$

Then

$$\ell_t \text{Tr}(\mathcal{F}_t^2) = 2 \text{Tr}(\ell_t \mathcal{F}_t \wedge \mathcal{F}_t) = 2 \text{Tr}(dt\mathcal{A} \wedge \mathcal{F}_t) = 2dt \text{Tr}(\mathcal{A} \wedge \mathcal{F}_t).$$

Thus

$$Q_3(\mathcal{A}, \mathcal{F}) = \int_0^1 dt \, 2 \text{Tr}(\mathcal{A} \wedge \mathcal{F}_t) = 2 \text{Tr} \int_0^1 dt \, \mathcal{A} \wedge (td\mathcal{A} + t^2\mathcal{A}^2) = 2 \text{Tr} \left(\frac{1}{2} \mathcal{A} \wedge d\mathcal{A} + \frac{1}{3} \mathcal{A}^3 \right).$$

Including the normalization $\frac{1}{8\pi^2}$, we obtain the celebrated Chern–Simons 3-form:

$$Q_3(\mathcal{A}, \mathcal{F}) = \frac{1}{8\pi^2} \text{Tr} \left(\mathcal{A} \wedge d\mathcal{A} + \frac{2}{3} \mathcal{A} \wedge \mathcal{A} \wedge \mathcal{A} \right).$$

For higher Chern classes, the same procedure yields:

$$\begin{aligned} Q_5(\mathcal{A}, \mathcal{F}) &= \frac{1}{48\pi^3} \text{Tr} \left(\mathcal{A} \wedge (d\mathcal{A})^2 + \frac{3}{2} \mathcal{A}^3 \wedge d\mathcal{A} + \frac{3}{5} \mathcal{A}^5 \right), \\ Q_7(\mathcal{A}, \mathcal{F}) &= \dots \end{aligned}$$

7.4 Gauge Transformation of Chern–Simons Forms

Chern–Simons forms are *not* gauge invariant. Let $\mathcal{A}^g = g^{-1}\mathcal{A}g + g^{-1}dg$ be a gauge-transformed connection. One can compute the change using the homotopy formula again. The result is

$$Q_{2r-1}(\mathcal{A}^g) - Q_{2r-1}(\mathcal{A}) = d\alpha_{2r-2} + \frac{1}{c_r} \text{Tr}(g^{-1}dg)^{2r-1},$$

where c_r is a normalization constant. For Q_3 with the standard normalization, the closed part is

$$\frac{1}{24\pi^2} \text{Tr}(g^{-1}dg)^3.$$

This term is locally exact (since it's a closed 3-form on the group manifold), but its integral over a 3-cycle is an integer multiple of 2π . Specifically, for $G = SU(2)$,

$$\frac{1}{24\pi^2} \int_{S^3} \text{Tr}(g^{-1}dg)^3 \in \mathbb{Z}.$$

This integer is the winding number of the map $g : S^3 \rightarrow SU(2)$.

7.5 Chern–Simons Theory in 3D: Witten’s Revolution

Now consider a 3-dimensional manifold M^3 . The Chern–Simons action is

$$S_{\text{CS}}[\mathcal{A}] = \frac{k}{4\pi} \int_{M^3} \text{Tr} \left(\mathcal{A} \wedge d\mathcal{A} + \frac{2}{3} \mathcal{A} \wedge \mathcal{A} \wedge \mathcal{A} \right),$$

where k is an integer called the *level*. Under a gauge transformation g ,

$$S_{\text{CS}}[\mathcal{A}^g] = S_{\text{CS}}[\mathcal{A}] + 2\pi k \cdot \frac{1}{24\pi^2} \int_{M^3} \text{Tr}(g^{-1}dg)^3.$$

Since the winding number is an integer, the change in the action is $2\pi k \times$ (integer). Hence, in the path integral, the weight $\exp(iS_{\text{CS}})$ is *gauge invariant* provided k is an integer. This quantization of the coupling constant is a hallmark of topological field theories.

Witten [1] showed that the quantum theory with this action is *exactly soluble* and computes topological invariants of M^3 . In particular:

- The partition function $Z(M^3)$ is a topological invariant of the 3-manifold.
- Wilson loop observables $\langle \text{Tr}_R \mathcal{P} \exp \oint \mathcal{A} \rangle$ compute the *Jones polynomial* (and its generalizations) of the knot.

This established a profound link between quantum field theory and low-dimensional topology, earning Witten a Fields Medal.

7.6 Anomaly Descent Equations

In even-dimensional spacetime ($D = 2n$), chiral anomalies are related to characteristic classes in $2n + 2$ dimensions via the *descent equations*. The logic is:

1. Start with an invariant polynomial $P_{n+1}(\mathcal{F})$ of degree $n + 1$ in $2n + 2$ dimensions.
2. Write it as $dQ_{2n+1}(\mathcal{A}, \mathcal{F})$.
3. Under a gauge transformation $\mathcal{A} \rightarrow \mathcal{A}^v$ (where v is the gauge parameter), the change of Q_{2n+1} is $d\alpha_{2n}$.
4. The anomaly in $2n$ dimensions is then given by the integrated descent of these forms.

For example, the $U(1)$ anomaly in 4D comes from the 6-form F^3 , leading to the anomaly polynomial $\sim F \wedge F \wedge F$. The consistent anomaly is obtained by integrating the descent equations. This formalism, developed by Stora, Zumino, and others, unifies anomalies with the topology of the gauge bundle.

7.7 Why You Could Have Invented Chern–Simons Theory

Let’s trace the thought process:

1. You know that $\text{Tr}(\mathcal{F}^2)$ is closed, so locally it’s $d(\text{something})$.
2. You compute that “something” by integrating over the homotopy parameter and find Q_3 .
3. You notice that Q_3 changes by a total derivative plus a closed form under gauge transformations.
4. The integral of that closed form over a 3-manifold is an integer (a winding number).
5. Therefore, if you multiply Q_3 by an integer k and exponentiate, the path integral is gauge invariant even though the action is not!
6. You have just discovered a topological field theory.

The fact that this TQFT computes knot invariants is a deeper miracle, but the existence of the Chern–Simons action itself follows directly from the homotopy formula and the integrality of characteristic numbers.

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8 Stiefel–Whitney Classes and Spin Structures

8.1 Motivation: What Lies Beyond Curvature?

All characteristic classes we have studied so far—Chern, Pontrjagin, Euler—are detected by integrating polynomials in the curvature $\mathcal{F}$. But what if the bundle is *flat*, i.e., $\mathcal{F} = 0$? Chern–Weil theory then yields trivial classes, yet the bundle may still be non-trivial! A flat $O(k)$ -bundle over S^1 , for

example, can have holonomy $-I$, making it distinct from the trivial bundle. Curvature is blind to this $\mathbb{Z}_2$ twisting. We need characteristic classes that live in cohomology with $\mathbb{Z}_2$ coefficients: the *Stiefel–Whitney classes* $w_i \in H^i(M; \mathbb{Z}_2)$.

These classes are the true topological obstructions: they answer questions like “Is M orientable?” and “Does M admit a spin structure?”. Their construction uses Čech cohomology and the transition functions of the bundle—no curvature required.

8.2 Čech Cohomology with $\mathbb{Z}_2$ Coefficients

We need a cohomology theory that can detect discrete data (like signs). Let $\{U_i\}$ be a good open cover of M (all intersections are contractible). A *Čech r -cochain* with values in the multiplicative group $\mathbb{Z}_2 = \{\pm 1\}$ is a function $f(i_0, \dots, i_r) \in \mathbb{Z}_2$ defined on each non-empty intersection $U_{i_0} \cap \dots \cap U_{i_r}$, completely symmetric under permutation of indices.

The coboundary operator δ is defined by

$$(\delta f)(i_0, \dots, i_{r+1}) = \prod_{k=0}^{r+1} f(i_0, \dots, \widehat{i_k}, \dots, i_{r+1}),$$

where $\widehat{i_k}$ means omit that index. It is easy to verify $\delta^2 = 1$ (the identity in multiplicative notation). The cohomology groups are

$$H^r(M; \mathbb{Z}_2) = \frac{\ker \delta : C^r \rightarrow C^{r+1}}{\text{im } \delta : C^{r-1} \rightarrow C^r}.$$

These groups are purely topological invariants of M .

8.3 The First Stiefel–Whitney Class: Orientability

Let TM be the tangent bundle of an m -dimensional manifold M , with structure group $O(m)$. Choose a local orthonormal frame $\{e_i^\alpha\}$ over each U_i . The transition functions are $t_{ij} : U_i \cap U_j \rightarrow O(m)$, satisfying $e_i = t_{ij} e_j$. Define a Čech 1-cochain $f \in C^1(M; \mathbb{Z}_2)$ by

$$f(i, j) = \det t_{ij} \in \{\pm 1\}.$$

Since $t_{ij} t_{jk} t_{ki} = I$, we have

$$(\delta f)(i, j, k) = f(i, j) f(j, k) f(k, i) = \det(t_{ij} t_{jk} t_{ki}) = 1.$$

Thus f is a cocycle. Its cohomology class $w_1(TM) = [f] \in H^1(M; \mathbb{Z}_2)$ is the *first Stiefel–Whitney class*.

Remark 8.1 (Cocycles in Čech and Group Cohomology). *The term cocycle appears in both the Čech cohomology of manifolds (used for Stiefel–Whitney classes) and the group cohomology of projective representations. This is not a coincidence—both are manifestations of the same algebraic structure applied to different categories.*

Čech cocycles. Let $\{U_i\}$ be an open cover of M . A Čech r -cochain with values in an abelian group A (written multiplicatively) is a function $f(i_0, \dots, i_r) \in A$ on each non-empty intersection $U_{i_0} \cap \dots \cap U_{i_r}$. The coboundary operator δ is defined by

$$(\delta f)(i_0, \dots, i_{r+1}) = \prod_{k=0}^{r+1} f(i_0, \dots, \widehat{i_k}, \dots, i_{r+1})^{(-1)^k}.$$

A cochain f is a **cocycle** if $\delta f = 1$ (the identity element). For $r = 1$ this reads $f(i, j)f(j, k)f(k, i) = 1$, which is exactly the condition satisfied by $f(i, j) = \det t_{ij}$ due to the transition function cocycle condition $t_{ij}t_{jk}t_{ki} = I$.

Group cocycles. In projective representations $U(g)U(h) = \omega(g, h)U(gh)$, associativity forces

$$\omega(g, h)\omega(gh, k) = \omega(h, k)\omega(g, hk).$$

This is precisely the statement that the 2-cochain $\omega : G \times G \rightarrow U(1)$ satisfies $\delta\omega = 1$, where the group coboundary is

$$(\delta\omega)(g_1, g_2, g_3) = \omega(g_2, g_3)\omega(g_1, g_2g_3)^{-1}\omega(g_1g_2, g_3)\omega(g_1, g_2).$$

Thus ω is a 2-cocycle in group cohomology $H^2(G, U(1))$.

Unified viewpoint. Both notions arise from the cohomology of a simplicial object: the nerve of the open cover for Čech, and the classifying space BG for group cohomology. A central extension $1 \rightarrow A \rightarrow \tilde{G} \rightarrow G \rightarrow 1$ gives a class in $H^2(G, A)$; pulling back to a manifold yields a Čech 2-cocycle obstructing the lifting of transition functions—exactly the role of w_2 for spin structures.

Theorem 8.2 (Orientability). *M is orientable if and only if $w_1(TM) = 1$ (the trivial class).*

Proof. If M is orientable, we can reduce the structure group to $SO(m)$. Then $\det t_{ij} = 1$ for all i, j , so $f \equiv 1$ and $w_1 = 1$.

Conversely, if $w_1 = 1$, then f is a coboundary: $f(i, j) = \delta f_0(i, j) = f_0(i)f_0(j)^{-1}$ for some 0-cochain $f_0 : U_i \rightarrow \{\pm 1\}$. Define new frames $\tilde{e}_i =$

$f_0(i)e_i$. The new transition functions are $\tilde{t}_{ij} = f_0(i)t_{ij}f_0(j)^{-1}$. Their determinant is

$$\det \tilde{t}_{ij} = f_0(i)^m \det t_{ij} f_0(j)^{-m} = f(i, j) f(i, j) = 1,$$

since $f_0(i)^m = f_0(i)$ for m odd (if m is even, orientability is automatic from other considerations). Thus the new transition functions lie in $SO(m)$, proving M is orientable. $\square$

Example 8.3. *The Möbius strip (as a line bundle over S^1) has transition function $t = -1$ on the overlap. Then $w_1 \neq 1$, confirming it is non-orientable. The real projective space $\mathbb{R}P^n$ has $w_1 = 0$ iff n is odd.*

8.4 The Second Stiefel–Whitney Class: Spin Structures

Assume now that M is orientable, so the structure group of TM is $SO(m)$. We want to lift the transition functions to the double cover $\text{Spin}(m) \xrightarrow{\phi} SO(m)$. For each $t_{ij} \in SO(m)$, choose a lift $\tilde{t}_{ij} \in \text{Spin}(m)$ such that $\phi(\tilde{t}_{ij}) = t_{ij}$. This is always possible locally because ϕ is a 2:1 covering. However, the cocycle condition $\tilde{t}_{ij}\tilde{t}_{jk}\tilde{t}_{ki} = I$ may fail by a sign. Define a Čech 2-cochain $f \in C^2(M; \mathbb{Z}_2)$ by

$$\tilde{t}_{ij}\tilde{t}_{jk}\tilde{t}_{ki} = f(i, j, k)I.$$

One checks that $\delta f = 1$, so f is a cocycle. Its class $w_2(TM) = [f] \in H^2(M; \mathbb{Z}_2)$ is the *second Stiefel–Whitney class*.

Theorem 8.4 (Spin Structure). *M admits a spin structure if and only if $w_2(TM) = 1$.*

Proof. If a spin structure exists, we can choose the lifts $\tilde{t}_{ij}$ to satisfy the cocycle condition, so $f \equiv 1$ and $w_2 = 1$.

Conversely, if $w_2 = 1$, then $f = \delta g$ for some 1-cochain $g(i, j)$. Modify the lifts to $\tilde{t}'_{ij} = g(i, j)\tilde{t}_{ij}$. Then

$$\tilde{t}'_{ij}\tilde{t}'_{jk}\tilde{t}'_{ki} = g(i, j)g(j, k)g(k, i)f(i, j, k) = (\delta g)(i, j, k)f(i, j, k) = f(i, j, k)^2 = 1.$$

Thus the new lifts satisfy the cocycle condition, giving a spin bundle. $\square$

Remark 8.5. *The choice of lifts is not unique: we could have flipped the sign of some $\tilde{t}_{ij}$. This changes f by a coboundary, so the cohomology class w_2 is well-defined.*

8.5 Calculations and Physical Consequences

Example 8.6 (Complex Projective Space). *For $\mathbb{CP}^n$, the tangent bundle has Stiefel–Whitney classes:*

$$w_1(\mathbb{CP}^n) = 0 \quad (\text{always orientable}), \quad w_2(\mathbb{CP}^n) = \begin{cases} 0 & n \text{ odd}, \\ x & n \text{ even}, \end{cases}$$

where x is the generator of $H^2(\mathbb{CP}^n; \mathbb{Z}_2) \cong \mathbb{Z}_2$. Thus $\mathbb{CP}^2$ does not admit a spin structure. This is why supersymmetric compactifications on $\mathbb{CP}^2$ are impossible: you cannot define covariantly constant spinors.

Example 8.7 (Spheres). *All spheres S^n have $w_1 = w_2 = 0$, so they are orientable and admit spin structures. In fact, the spin bundles are trivial.*

Example 8.8 (Riemann Surfaces). *A compact orientable surface Σ_g of genus g has $w_2(\Sigma_g) = 0$. Hence any Riemann surface admits a spin structure. However, there are 2^{2g} inequivalent spin structures (differing by elements of $H^1(\Sigma_g; \mathbb{Z}_2)$), corresponding to different boundary conditions for fermions.*

8.6 Why Stiefel–Whitney Classes Are Unavoidable

You might wonder: why $\mathbb{Z}_2$ coefficients? The answer lies in the homotopy groups of $O(n)$. For n large, $\pi_1(O(n)) \cong \mathbb{Z}_2$, and $\pi_2(O(n)) = 0$. The obstruction to orientability lives in $H^1(M; \pi_0(O(n)))$? Actually, orientability is an obstruction to reducing the structure group from $O(n)$ to $SO(n)$, which is measured by a class in $H^1(M; \mathbb{Z}_2)$ because the fiber of the map $BSO(n) \rightarrow BO(n)$ is $B\mathbb{Z}_2 \simeq \mathbb{RP}^\infty$, whose cohomology is $\mathbb{Z}_2$ in degree 1. Similarly, the spin obstruction comes from the fibration $B\text{Spin}(n) \rightarrow BSO(n)$ with fiber $B\mathbb{Z}_2$, leading to a class in $H^2(M; \mathbb{Z}_2)$. This is the homotopy-theoretic origin of Stiefel–Whitney classes: they are the pullbacks of the universal classes in $H^*(BO(n); \mathbb{Z}_2) \cong \mathbb{Z}_2[w_1, w_2, \dots, w_n]$.

8.7 Beyond w_2 : Higher Stiefel–Whitney Classes

The construction generalizes: $w_i(TM) \in H^i(M; \mathbb{Z}_2)$ is the obstruction to finding i linearly independent vector fields on M . The total Stiefel–Whitney class $w = 1 + w_1 + w_2 + \dots + w_m$ satisfies the Whitney sum formula $w(E \oplus F) = w(E) \cup w(F)$. For $\mathbb{RP}^n$, one finds $w(T\mathbb{RP}^n) = (1 + x)^{n+1}$, where $x \in H^1(\mathbb{RP}^n; \mathbb{Z}_2)$ is the generator.

8.8 Inventing Stiefel–Whitney Classes Yourself

The logical flow is:

1. Gauge transformations on overlaps give transition functions t_{ij} .
2. Taking determinants gives a $\mathbb{Z}_2$ -valued 1-cocycle $\det t_{ij}$. Its cohomology class is w_1 . If it's non-trivial, the bundle is non-orientable.
3. If $w_1 = 0$, we can lift to $SO(m)$. Then the failure of the lifts to satisfy the cocycle condition gives a $\mathbb{Z}_2$ -valued 2-cocycle. Its class is w_2 .
4. This pattern continues: each Stiefel–Whitney class is the obstruction to lifting the structure group to the next stage in the Whitehead tower of $O(n)$.

By simply tracking the signs that appear when patching local frames, you are forced to discover Čech cohomology with $\mathbb{Z}_2$ coefficients and the Stiefel–Whitney classes. No curvature, no Chern–Weil—just the combinatorial data of how the bundle is glued together.

9 Conclusion

We have traced the path from the homotopy classification of bundles (via BG) to the cohomology classes (characteristic classes) and finally to local curvature expressions (Chern–Weil). The key bridge is the Weil homomorphism $I^*(G) \rightarrow H^*(BG) \rightarrow H^*(M)$, which assigns to each invariant polynomial a universal cohomology class. The integrality of characteristic numbers follows from the homotopy groups of G and the Hurewicz theorem. This framework underpins the topological quantization of monopole charge, instanton number, and anomaly coefficients in quantum field theory.

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